a sustained campaign with a pan-UP sweep, with the fixed leg of the compass anchored in western UP.

At Dadri, Akhilesh raised questions on unemployment, farmer distress, and what he described as a rending of the social fabric. From 'bulldozer justice' to other law-and-order methods, he framed the BJP's governance as one that prioritises

ternity) Rally', which mobilised Jats, Gujjars, Muslims and Yadavs equally. Gujjars, first among those still receptive to Hindutva in these parts, have emerged as a key target of the SP's broader non-Yadav OBC strategy. Influential across many seats in western UP, Dadri typifies it—at 30 per cent, they are the largest vote bloc here.

Akhilesh's outreach was not without a resort to heady identity politics, centring around the 9th century ruler Mihir Bhoj—the subject of a hot patent dispute between Gujjars and Rajputs. In 2021, a statue unveiled by CM Yogi Adityanath here had 'Gurjar' removed at the last minute so as not to offend Rajputs. That had led to protests and blackening of posters. Akhilesh explicitly backed the Gujjar claim and promised a Mihir Bhoj statue on the Gomti riverfront in Lucknow.

On farmer issues, he promised compensation at market rates for acquired land, accusing the BJP of underpaying farmers while congratulating itself for 'empty' airport projects.

In 2024, the SP had done well in several Jat- and Gujjar-heavy seats. Still, it's a steep challenge. In the 2022 assembly election, the BJP had won 93 of western UP's 140 seats. ■



SUMIT KUMAR

ON THE TRAIL SP chief Akhilesh Yadav in Dadri, Mar. 29

Takeaways

- **A 'fraternity' push aims to attract diverse groups to SP**
- **Gujjars, a big OBC group, receive special outreach**

confrontation. This venture into the difficult art of social alliance-making intends to persuade voters to respond instead to common livelihood issues.

The 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots are the unspoken backdrop here. Efforts by the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) since 2019 had helped suture the Jat-Muslim divide to a degree. But it hitched wagons with the BJP in 2024. The SP has spotted a gap to fill. Thus was coined the 'Samajwadi Samaanta Bhaichara (Socialist Equality Fra-

By **Jumana Shah**

CHANGE IS A WORD THAT HAS BEEN EXILED from Gujarat's political vocabulary for the better part of three decades, and nothing on the horizon suggests its return. Yet within the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) itself, something is shifting. Six months in, new state president Jagdish Vishwakarma has quietly pressed a reset. Key posts stand reshuffled, candidate selection has been opened up. Both are tied to a larger process: a sprawling organisation working to reconnect back to its booth-level roots.

Thirty years of unbroken rule had become the BJP's silent problem. With no sharp opposition keeping it on its toes, its cadre was losing the one thing a political machine can't afford to lose—urgency. Fighting and winning elections is a separate discipline. Booth-level SOPs kick in with clockwork precision; it's not harmed by peacetime lethargy, nor can it cure that. In fact, each win deepens the disease.

ELECTORAL TEST

Vishwakarma's elevation came after a rather long wait; predecessor C.R. Paatil, his original tenure technically ended in 2023, was on an extended run. But its timing left the new boss a decent window before the next electoral test. That comes up now: 15 municipal corporations, 84 municipalities, 34 district panchayats and 260 taluka panchayats vote on April 26.

These are typically fought on hyper-local issues but, cumulatively, end up serving as a referendum on the ruling party. So this is an early bellwether for the assembly election due in December 2027.

That's what 'Jagdishbhai' is laser-focused on, with a renewed earth connect. "He has visited all 32 districts at least once. He has 'tiffin meetings' over breakfast and lunch at workers' homes, eating out of tiffin